

OPWDD Application & Admission Process Guide

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Overview

The Office for People With Developmental Disabilities (OPWDD) is the New York State agency that provides supports and services to people with developmental disabilities, including intellectual disability, autism spectrum disorder, cerebral palsy, epilepsy, and other neurological impairments. Getting connected to OPWDD involves two distinct phases: (1) an eligibility determination confirming the person has a qualifying developmental disability, and (2) enrollment/service planning through the "Front Door," which connects an eligible person to an actual Care Coordination Organization (CCO) and services. Being found eligible does NOT automatically mean services start immediately — enrollment and planning are a separate next step.

Step 1: Contact the OPWDD Front Door

"Front Door" is OPWDD's name for the entry point into the whole system. Anyone new to OPWDD, or wanting to explore services, should start here.

- Statewide OPWDD Information Line: 1-866-946-9733 (or email info@opwdd.ny.gov) — for general questions, complaints, or being directed to your regional Front Door office.
- Translation/language access services are available on request (email language.access.requests@opwdd.ny.gov).
- At the Front Door stage, OPWDD staff will explain the process, answer questions about supports and services, and help identify next steps.
- Families/individuals attend a Front Door information session (available in English, Spanish, and Chinese) which explains what to expect.

NYC Developmental Disabilities Regional Offices (DDROs) — Region 4 (Metro NYC)

Each borough has its own regional office:

Bronx DDRO 2400 Halsey Street, Bronx, NY 10461 Phone: (718) 430-0757

Brooklyn DDRO 888 Fountain Avenue, Brooklyn, NY 11208 Phone: (718) 642-8576

Manhattan DDRO 25 Beaver Street, 4th Floor, New York, NY 10004 Phone: (646) 766-3220

Queens DDRO 80-45 Winchester Blvd., Queens Village, NY 11427 Phone: (718) 217-6485

Staten Island DDRO 1150 Forest Hill Road, Staten Island, NY 10314 Phone: (718) 982-1913

Step 2: Gather Required Documentation

Before or shortly after contacting the Front Door, you'll need to assemble records proving a qualifying developmental disability that began before age 22. The OPWDD Transmittal Form for Determination of Developmental Disability must accompany the application. Required documents typically include:

1. **Psychological evaluation report** — must be less than 3 years old. Must include a full-scale IQ score (all summary scores: Full Scale, Index, Part, and Subtest) from a standardized test such as WISC-V, WAIS-IV, or Stanford-Binet V.
2. **Adaptive behavior assessment** — a standardized, comprehensive (not abbreviated/"domain-only") interpretive report, such as the Vineland Adaptive Behavior Scales or ABAS, with summary, composite, scale, and domain scores. (Generally required if IQ is above 60.)
3. **Medical or specialty report** — required for diagnoses other than intellectual disability (e.g., autism, cerebral palsy, epilepsy) — must include health status and diagnostic findings. Must be less than 12 months old.
4. **General/physical medical summary** — completed within the past 12 months (an annual physical report often suffices).
5. **Social history / psychosocial evaluation report** — less than 1 year old, showing the disability began before age 22, including social and background information (living situation, work history if any). Not needed separately if this info is already covered in the psychological report.
6. **Helpful (not always required) additional documents:** Most recent IEP or 504 Plan and referenced psychoeducational reports; mental health evaluation records (intake, discharge, treatment plans — not day-to-day progress notes).

Tip: Many people who are found eligible have either an IQ score below 70 with 2+ adaptive scores in the "low" range, OR an IQ above 70 with 3+ adaptive scores in the "low" range — but this is a general pattern, not a strict cutoff.

Documents are uploaded into OPWDD's CHOICES system, and the CCO mailbox is emailed to confirm submission.

Step 3: Eligibility Determination — the Three-Step Review Process

Once a complete application is submitted, the Developmental Disabilities Regional Office (DDRO) reviews it through up to three review steps:

1st Step Review: DDRO staff check the eligibility request for completeness. If anything is missing, you'll be asked for more documents.

2nd Step Review: A committee of clinicians evaluates the full application and supporting evidence. They may request additional information or a further evaluation, and may recommend where to obtain it or arrange it directly. You'll receive a written decision — approved or denied.

3rd Step Review (if needed): If you disagree with the decision, you can request a further, independent committee review, and if still unresolved, a Medicaid Fair Hearing.

Timeline: The statutory timeline is 60 days from receipt of a complete application. In practice, NYC-area families report 45–90 days depending on regional office caseload and case complexity. A face-to-face interview may be part of the process depending on complexity.

Important: Eligibility confirms you have access to the OPWDD system — it does NOT mean you're automatically enrolled in specific services. Some services also require additional reviews beyond basic eligibility (e.g., Medicaid enrollment, waiver-specific criteria).

Step 4: Choose a Care Coordination Organization (CCO)

After eligibility is approved, you select one of the three Care Coordination Organizations (CCOs) serving New York City. A CCO assigns a Care Manager who helps navigate Medicaid enrollment, gather further paperwork, coordinate assessments, and build your person-centered Life Plan (a living document outlining goals, needs, strengths, preferences, services, and providers). You can switch CCOs or care managers at any time, and you choose your own level of involvement/support from the care manager.

The Three CCOs Serving All Five Boroughs

1. Advance Care Alliance (ACA/NY) General Line: 1-833-692-2269 Website: advancecarealliance.org

2. Care Design NY General/Bronx: (646) 491-6497 Website: caredesignny.org Borough-specific enrollment specialists:

- Bronx — Kelly Rios (bilingual Spanish): (646) 491-6497 x4027
- Brooklyn — Luz Obando (bilingual Spanish): (347) 227-0817 x3215

- Queens — Peter Coleman: (718) 532-4812 x2047
- Manhattan/NYC & Staten Island — Todd Brilliant: (646) 491-6497 x4050

3. Tri-County Care General Line: 1-844-504-8400 (press 0) Website: [tricountycare.org](https://www.tricountycare.org)

If issues arise at the CCO level, escalate to the Care Coordination Support Liaison at the borough's DDRO:

- Queens: Maryneily Rodriguez, (718) 722-2499, maryneily.s.rodriguez@opwdd.ny.gov
- Brooklyn: Lorraine Dowling, (718) 722-2764, Lorraine.d.dowling@opwdd.ny.gov
- Metro Manhattan: Marjorie Allen, (718) 430-0887, Marjorie.A.Allen@opwdd.ny.gov
- Metro Bronx: Marjorie Allen, (718) 430-0371, Marjorie.A.Allen@opwdd.ny.gov
- Staten Island: Henry Njibe, (718) 264-3952, Henry.Njibe@opwdd.ny.gov

Step 5: Complete the DDP-2 Phone Interview

After the Front Door session, an OPWDD representative will call to complete a Developmental Disabilities Profile (DDP-2) — a detailed intake form covering functional needs and history. It can take up to an hour, so schedule it for a time with no distractions and have any relevant records handy. It can help to review the DDP-2 form in advance.

Step 6: Medicaid Enrollment

Most OPWDD services are Medicaid-funded and require no out-of-pocket cost to families, but Medicaid enrollment is a separate step from OPWDD eligibility.

- Adults can apply through NY State of Health: 1-855-355-5777
- Help completing the Medicaid application is also available at 1-800-541-2831
- Your CCO will guide you through Medicaid enrollment as part of the intake process
- If already connected to a community service agency, their staff may also help with the Medicaid application

Step 7: Service Planning & Enrollment ("Life Plan")

With a CCO and Care Manager in place, the person-centered planning process begins. Your Care Manager helps develop a Life Plan — an evolving, individualized plan covering goals, support needs, strengths, preferences, chosen services/providers, and safety/backup plans. Services actually delivered are determined through this planning process, which continues to be updated over time as needs and goals change.

Self-Direction Option

Families/individuals can choose "self-direction" for more control over which services and staff are used, but this comes with more responsibility (hiring, scheduling, budgeting,

oversight). This is worth discussing with your Care Manager if more flexibility and control is desired.

Key Reminders & Tips

- **Start early:** Advocacy organizations recommend beginning the eligibility process no later than age 14–15 for anyone approaching the end of school-based services — earlier is better, since the process can take months.
- **Eligibility ≠ services:** Determination of eligibility opens the door to the system; specific services still require enrollment and planning.
- **Documents expire:** Psychological evaluations are valid up to 3 years; medical, social history, and adaptive assessments generally need to be under 1 year old at submission.
- **You can switch CCOs any time** if the fit isn't right.
- **Get help reviewing documents:** YAI LINK (link@yai.org, (212) 273-6182, yai.org/link) and New York Lawyers for the Public Interest (NYLPI) can help review eligibility paperwork before submission.
- **Appeal rights exist:** If found ineligible, you can request further review and, if needed, a Medicaid Fair Hearing.

Quick Reference: Who to Call

Need	Contact
General OPWDD questions/complaints	1-866-946-9733 / info@opwdd.ny.gov
Bronx DDRO	(718) 430-0757
Brooklyn DDRO	(718) 642-8576
Manhattan DDRO	(646) 766-3220
Queens DDRO	(718) 217-6485
Staten Island DDRO	(718) 982-1913
Advance Care Alliance (CCO)	1-833-692-2269
Care Design NY (CCO)	(646) 491-6497
Tri-County Care (CCO)	1-844-504-8400
Medicaid application (adults)	1-855-355-5777
Medicaid application help	1-800-541-2831
YAI LINK (document review help)	(212) 273-6182

Sources: OPWDD official eligibility guidelines and Front Door materials (opwdd.ny.gov), INCLUDEnyc, Advocates for Children of New York. Verify current phone numbers/timelines directly with OPWDD, as agency contacts and processing times can change.